

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 148

By McNally

A RESOLUTION to commend and recognize The Ayers Foundation on the occasion of its twenty-fifth anniversary.

WHEREAS, it is appropriate that we pay tribute to those exemplary organizations that work with purpose and conviction to improve the quality of life in their communities; and

WHEREAS, one such estimable charitable venture, The Ayers Foundation, has been making a difference in the lives of Tennesseans for the past twenty-five years; and

WHEREAS, The Ayers Foundation was founded by Jim Ayers, who grew up in the West Tennessee town of Parsons and recognized firsthand the disparity between those promising students whose families could afford a college education and those whose families could not; and

WHEREAS, after completing his college education, Mr. Ayers found great success in the healthcare management and banking industries, eventually becoming the sole owner of FirstBank, Tennessee's largest independently owned and operated bank; and

WHEREAS, he established The Ayers Foundation in 1999, and in the twenty-five years since, the organization has made an important, lasting impact on the lives of many Tennesseans; and

WHEREAS, The Ayers Foundation supports a wide range of programs and institutions, with an emphasis on education in Henderson, Perry, and Decatur counties; in its first decade of operation, it awarded more than 3,000 scholarships; and

WHEREAS, The Ayers Foundation has been able to greatly expand its Ayers Scholars Program as Governor Bill Lee and the General Assembly invested in the Ayers Foundation

Trust to scale the program to seven additional counties in 2021 and an additional ten counties in 2023; and

WHEREAS, now serving students in all three Grand Divisions of the State of Tennessee, The Ayers Foundation provides educational services to thirty-three high schools in twenty-one counties; and

WHEREAS, in addition to helping young people get an education, The Ayers Foundation provides support and works closely with Come Home Tennessee, the Ayers Entrepreneur Center, Ayers Children's Medical Center in West Tennessee, Ayers Institute for Pre-Cancer Detection at Vanderbilt, Ayers Institute for Learning and Innovation at Lipscomb University, Janet Ayers Center at Belmont University, and The TRAIN Program-TN Rural Acceleration and Innovation Network; and

WHEREAS, it is most fitting that we recognize this exemplary charitable endeavor on this auspicious occasion; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and commend The Ayers Foundation for its twenty-five years of devoted service to the State of Tennessee, applauding its continuing efforts to improve the quality of life for all Tennesseans.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.